STIVEN CATALYST

FIRST SERIES · OCTOBER 2026

MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



PEOPLE

PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY: WHEN PEOPLE SPEAK UP

What it is and what it is not, why Google put it first in its research on teams, and how a manager builds it, one shift at a time.

43% of respondents in a McKinsey global survey report a positive climate in their team.

MCKINSEY, 2021

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NO. 04 · PEOPLE

In this issue

A team learns only from what its people dare to say: the mistake, the doubt, the question that sounds naive. The subject here is the climate that makes that possible, and the manager's part in it.

The idea comes from Amy Edmondson's research in the 1990s. Google found it at the top of its own study of teams in 2015, and a meta-analysis of 136 samples has since linked it to how people work and perform. It is also easily mistaken for niceness, or for permission to lower standards.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

The best teams reported more errors

In the mid-1990s Amy Edmondson studied medication errors in hospital units. The units with better leadership and better relationships had more detected errors, not fewer.

Edmondson's explanation: the number of detected errors depends on two things, how many happen and how many people are willing to report. Where people were not afraid, mistakes came to the surface and could be learned from. Three years later Edmondson defined the idea.

TEAM PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY · EDMONDSON, 1999

A shared belief held by members of a team that the team is safe for interpersonal risk taking.

Such risks include admitting a mistake or asking for help. The 1999 study looked at 51 work teams in a manufacturing company and found it linked to the team's learning behaviour.

1996
Hospital units: more errors detected where people speak up.

1999
The definition, tested in 51 work teams.

2015
Google puts it first among five team dynamics.

2017
A meta-analysis of 136 samples.

OUR READING

When a team reports no problems, sometimes the reason is that nobody speaks.

Sources: Amy Edmondson, Journal of Applied Behavioral Science, 1996 (via AHRQ PSNet); Amy Edmondson, Administrative Science Quarterly, 1999; Google re:Work, 2015; M. Lance Frazier, Stav Fainshmidt, Ryan L. Klinger, Amir Pezeshkan & Veselina Vracheva, Personnel Psychology, 2017 (via Abstract; QIC-WD and Michigan MDHHS summaries)

THE NUMBERS

What the research says

Two large bodies of evidence, one inside a single company, one across many studies, point the same way. A third shows how far most teams still are.

180+
Google teams studied in Project Aristotle

200+
interviews, and more than 250 team attributes

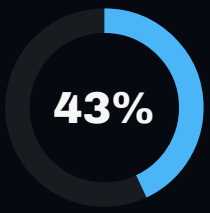
5
dynamics found, with psychological safety first

136
independent samples in the 2017 meta-analysis

22,000+
people in those samples

≈5,000
groups and teams

The meta-analysis links psychological safety to task performance and to engagement. Most of the studies measured at one point in time, so they show a link, not proof of cause.



of respondents in a McKinsey global survey during the pandemic reported a positive team climate. McKinsey found the leader's own behaviour had the most influence on it.

Sources: Google re:Work, 2015; M. Lance Frazier, Stav Fainshmidt, Ryan L. Klinger, Amir Pezeshkan & Veselina Vracheva, Personnel Psychology, 2017 (via Abstract; QIC-WD and Michigan MDHHS summaries); McKinsey & Company, 2021

THE MODEL

Five things that make a team work

Google's researchers found that how a team works together mattered more than who was on it. These are the five dynamics, with the question behind each, in our words.

01 **Psychological safety**
Can we take a risk on this team without feeling insecure or embarrassed?

02 **Dependability**
Can we count on each other to do good work on time?

03 **Structure and clarity**
Are our goals, roles and plans clear?

04 **Meaning**
Is the work personally important to each of us?

05 **Impact**
Do we believe that what we do matters?

OUR READING

Without the first, the other four are hard to reach. A team that does not dare to say "I am behind" will not stay dependable for long.

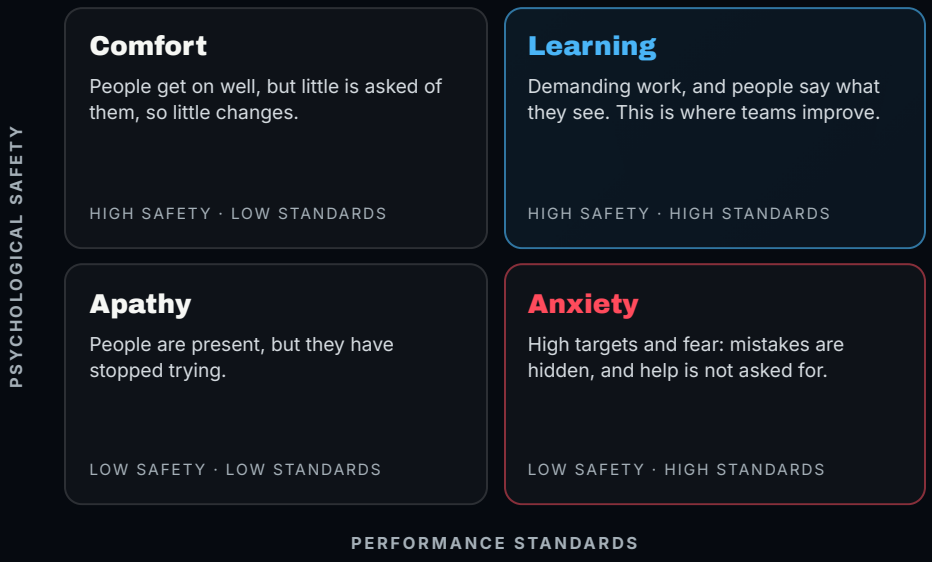
Source: Google re:Work, 2015

More in the essay — Leading people without losing the person

WHAT IT IS NOT

Safety without standards is only comfort

Edmondson places psychological safety beside a second dimension: how high the standards are. Only the two together lead to learning.



OUR READING

Psychological safety is neither niceness nor a lower bar. It means keeping the bar high and making it safe to say that you are not over it yet.

Source: Amy C. Edmondson, 2018

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Ask the team, not yourself

Edmondson measured psychological safety with seven statements that the members of a team rate, about mistakes, problems, differences, risk, help, trust and skills. The manager's own impression does not count as a measurement.

1. **Anonymous**
   Answers without names, and results only for the whole team.
2. **Talk about the lowest item**
   The aim is to understand what makes it hard. Who scored it low does not matter.
3. **Change one behaviour**
   For example, thank the first person who brings bad news in the briefing.
4. **Ask again**
   After two or three months, with the same questions.

OUR READING

The way a manager reacts to the first bad news decides whether there will be a second.

Source: Amy Edmondson, Administrative Science Quarterly, 1999

The four steps are a practice proposed by the editors.

More in the essay How to talk to someone who made a mistake

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

Seven questions for your team

Ask each person to rate the seven statements without a name. Collect the cards, add them up, and talk about the lowest one together.

1 = not at all · 5 = completely		1	2	3	4	5
01	If I make a mistake here, it is not held against me.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
02	We can bring up problems and difficult issues.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
03	Nobody is pushed aside for being different.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
04	It is safe to try something new here.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
05	It is easy to ask the others for help.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
06	Nobody here would deliberately undermine my work.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
07	My skills are valued and used.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

After the card

1. Look at the statement with the lowest total.
2. Ask the team what would make it a 5, and listen.
3. Fill it in again after two or three months.

The statements are in our words, inspired by Edmondson's scale (1999). Use the card for the team, never to rate a person.

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Learning from Mistakes Is Easier Said Than Done
Amy Edmondson, Journal of Applied Behavioral Science, 1996 · via AHRQ PSNet
https://doi.org/10.1177/0021886396321001

Psychological Safety and Learning Behavior in Work Teams
Amy Edmondson, Administrative Science Quarterly, 1999
https://doi.org/10.2307/2666999

Understand team effectiveness (Project Aristotle)
Google re:Work, 2015
https://rework.withgoogle.com/intl/en/guides/understand-team-effectiveness

Psychological Safety: A Meta-Analytic Review and Extension
M. Lance Frazier, Stav Fainshmidt, Ryan L. Klinger, Amir Pezeshkan & Veselina Vracheva, Personnel Psychology, 2017 · via Abstract; QIC-WD and Michigan MDHHS summaries
https://doi.org/10.1111/peps.12183

Psychological safety and the critical role of leadership development
McKinsey & Company, 2021
https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/people-and-organizational-performance/our-insights/psychological-safety-and-the-critical-role-of-leadership-development

The Fearless Organization
Amy C. Edmondson, 2018

CORRECTION · 16 OCTOBER 2026

The introduction now places Amy Edmondson's 1996 study on hospital wards; it first said one hospital. Her study looked at care teams in two hospitals.

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

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